Separate the event from the story

An interpretation may be worth exploring. It is not yet an established fact.

What a camera could capture

We agreed Wednesday. The file arrived Friday.
Specific dates, words, messages or deliverables.

The meaning you added

You do not care about this project.
A conclusion about motive that needs checking.

TRY IT / O OBSERVATION I INTERPRETATION M MIXTURE

- [ ] 1. You have stopped caring about this project.
- [ ] 2. We agreed a Wednesday hand-off. The file arrived on Friday.
- [ ] 3. You interrupted because you do not respect my role.
- [ ] 4. During my update, you began speaking before I finished on two occasions.
- [ ] 5. Everyone is frustrated with your attitude.

Rewrite statements 1 3 and 5 or say what you need to verify

My facts / What was agreed and what did I observe

My assumptions / What could change my interpretation

Fairness check: do not let one recent event erase earlier good work, or earlier good work hide a current issue.

Build an opening in four parts

Use this as a thinking aid. Adapt the words so they sound like you.

1 Purpose

I would like us to make our next supplier hand-off more predictable.

YOUR WORDS

2 Observation

We agreed Tuesday at 2 pm. I received the draft Wednesday at 11 am.

YOUR WORDS

3 Work impact

I moved the review, and the next task started a day later.

YOUR WORDS

4 Invitation

What affected the hand-off from your side?

YOUR WORDS

Speak it once. Remove one loaded phrase. Write the version you will use.

Check before moving on: one issue, a verifiable event, a direct work impact and a real invitation. Keep it to about a minute. Could the other person give an answer that changes your view?

Your conversation plan

Keep brief notes beside you so you can listen during the meeting.

1 Person topic time and place

2 Purpose and what is open to discussion

3 Reliable observations and direct impact

4 Two questions and an assumption to check

5 My opening

6 My contribution to the situation

7 Likely difficulty my response and pause plan

8 Proposed action support and review point

9 Anything needing another process or approval

Before you go: check your facts, clarify what is negotiable and choose one question whose answer could change your view.